

DarkSword: iPhone Exploit Kit Serves Spies & Thieves Alike

CyberIntel Threat Advisory - automated analysis of source reporting: affected systems, actor attribution, and recommended actions.

INTELLIGENCE SNAPSHOT

Issued by	CyberIntel
Date	15 June 2026
Source	darkreading
Region	Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Malaysia, Ukraine
Threat Level	CRITICAL
Focus	iPhone Exploit Kit
Motivations	Financial, Espionage
Prominent Actors	UNC6353 (suspected Russian espionage group), PARS Defense (Turkish surveillance vendor)
Primary Tactics	Phishing, Exploit Chain, Remote Code Execution, Sandbox Escape, Privilege Escalation
Affected Systems / Vendors	iPhone (iOS versions 18.4 through 18.7)
CVEs	CVE-2025-31277, CVE-2025-43529, CVE-2026-20700, CVE-2025-14174, CVE-2025-43510, CVE-2025-43520
Reference	https://www.darkreading.com/threat-intelligence/darksword-iphone-exploit-spies-thieves
Classification	For Authorised Recipients

Executive Summary

A sophisticated iOS exploit chain, known as DarkSword, has been discovered to be targeting iPhone users in Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Malaysia, and Ukraine. The exploit chain leverages multiple zero-day vulnerabilities to fully compromise devices, allowing for remote code execution, sandbox escape, and privilege escalation. The vulnerabilities include JavaScriptCore memory corruption flaws, dyld user-mode pointer authentication code bypass, ANGLE memory corruption flaw, iOS kernel memory management flaw, and iOS kernel memory corruption bug. The exploit chain is being used by both espionage actors and financially motivated attackers, with the ability to collect sensitive data from the victim's phone and target cryptocurrency wallets. The use of DarkSword by multiple threat actors, including suspected state-sponsored groups and commercial surveillance vendors, highlights the complexity and accessibility of iOS zero-day and n-day exploits. The fact that the exploit chain can be executed with a single click and can remove itself from the target device after collecting data makes it a significant threat. The discovery of DarkSword and its predecessor, Coruna, raises concerns about the market for iOS zero-day and n-day exploits and the potential for these capabilities to be used by a wide range of threat actors.

■ THREAT LEVEL: CRITICAL

FOCUS: IPHONE EXPLOIT KIT

Threat Actor Profiles & Operational Structure

UNC6353

Suspected Russian espionage group

Capabilities: Sophisticated exploit chain usage, potential access to substantial funding

Confirmed Activities: Launched watering hole attacks against Ukrainian users using DarkSword exploit chain

Critical Infrastructure & Notable Sector Impacts

Sector	Targeted Entity / System	Actor	Impact / Method
Government	Saudi Arabian users	PARS Defense	Targeted with phony website promising secure Snapchat messaging
Finance	Cryptocurrency wallets	UNC6353	Targeted for financial gain

Initial Access Vectors & TTPs

Threat Actor	Documented Attack Vectors & TTPs
General	Phishing, Exploit Chain, Remote Code Execution, Sandbox Escape, Privilege Escalation
UNC6353	Watering hole attacks, DarkSword exploit chain usage

Detection Measures & Mitigation Strategy

- ✓ **Regular iOS updates.** Keeping devices updated with the latest OS can prevent exploitation of known vulnerabilities
- ✓ **Lockdown Mode.** Enabling Lockdown Mode can provide an additional layer of security against exploit chains like DarkSword
- ✓ **Network traffic monitoring.** Monitoring network traffic can help detect and prevent exploit chain attacks
- ✓ **Device security audits.** Regular security audits can help identify and mitigate potential vulnerabilities in iOS devices

CyberIntel Strategic Recommendations

- ✓ **Keep iOS devices updated.** Regularly update iOS devices to the latest version to prevent exploitation of known vulnerabilities
- ✓ **Enable Lockdown Mode.** Consider enabling Lockdown Mode to provide an additional layer of security against exploit chains like DarkSword
- ✓ **Implement network traffic monitoring.** Implement network traffic monitoring to detect and prevent exploit chain attacks
- ✓ **Conduct regular security audits.** Conduct regular security audits to identify and mitigate potential vulnerabilities in iOS devices

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